Storytelling and analogies

Making an explanation coherent and memorable

Use a story or analogy when it clarifies a sequence, relationship or abstract idea. Keep the narrative tied to the disciplinary meaning students must learn.

How to do it well

1 Identify the relationship. Decide what the story or comparison will make easier to understand.

2 Select a familiar structure. Use a short sequence or analogy students can follow without extensive new background.

3 Explain the mapping. Link the important narrative features to the subject concept and show the cause or relationship.

4 State the boundary. Identify a way the analogy differs from the target idea before that difference becomes a misconception.

5 Translate back. Ask students to explain the concept in disciplinary terms and apply it to an example outside the original story.

What this sounds like

“Think of this as a pressure cooker building tension. In the text, what represents the pressure? Where does the analogy help, and where does it stop being accurate?”

Classroom example. An English teacher uses a short analogy to explain mounting tension in a text. Each part of the comparison is mapped to evidence, and a limitation is named. Pupils then explain the tension using subject vocabulary and quotations. The analogy helps access the idea without becoming a substitute for precise textual analysis.

Top tips that make the technique work

Keep cause and consequence visible. A story should help explain why an event or change occurs, not merely entertain.

Map the analogy explicitly. State what each part represents in the target idea.

Name the limits. Tell students where the familiar comparison stops being accurate.

Remove unnecessary detail. Interesting characters or episodes can become the remembered feature instead of the concept.

Return to subject language. Students need to explain the idea without relying on the story alone.

Do and avoid

Do	Avoid
Choose a narrative that carries the intended explanation.	A memorable story with an unclear learning point.
Connect it back to precise vocabulary.	Treating an analogy as literally identical to the concept.

Further reading

Practitioner guidance; teacher language above is an illustrative BSCS adaptation. Some links support part of this guide rather than the whole technique.

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